

SYMBIAN Or NOT

“Symbian is addictive”, said a user, very recently on a popular forum. What is Symbian? Symbian is the operating system used by most smartphones these days. This replaces the typical firmware, with an actual OS, which supports installation and removal of compatible applications, to improve usability and productivity of the cellphone.

There are different series of operating systems for different phones. The Symbian 60, 80 and 90 series are open-ended platforms used exclusively by Nokia. Similar is the Symbian UIQ platform used by Sony Ericsson, for their high-end P series smartphones. Some bestselling examples of Symbian devices are the Nokia 7650, 6600, 6630, 7710, N70, and Sony Ericsson's P800, 900 and 910 cellphones.

Symbian based smartphones could very well replace the PDA in the near future. A typical ‘road warrior’ manager, has to be productive in office as well as in the back seat of a taxi. To do so he typically needs three gadgets, his laptop, his PDA and his cell phone. While on the move, a laptop becomes an encumbrance of sorts, and could actually hinder productivity. The PDA typically alleviates this problem, while losing out on the ability to stay connected. This is where the cell phone, or rather *smart* cell phone scores.

One of the major reasons why Symbian enjoys advantages like much speedier interface and improved security over even a PDA OS like MS Windows Mobile, is the use of the Symbian C++ development platform as compared to the .NET framework that Windows Mobile uses. With support for features like multi-threading, memory protection and pre-

emptive multitasking Symbian is not only faster, but more robust for day to day mobile needs also.

One of the reasons for insufficient penetration of Symbian in the handheld market is the dearth of Symbian C++ programmers. The learning curve of Symbian C++ is such that even C++ and Java professionals have to spend a lot of time learning its ins and outs. This isn't the case with Windows Mobile as the .NET development environment is very programmer friendly. Another limitation of Symbian is that the OS was designed for use on the ARM series of processors.

One of its biggest merits is the support for third party applications. The Symbian OS is so flexible that keeping a series in mind applications can and have been developed for use on Symbian phones. The best possible example is perhaps the Nokia 6600, one of the first series 60 smartphones. Applications developed for it range from Web browsers to even applications that allow your cell phone to act as a remote control for certain TVs and DVD players. In fact, more applications were developed for Symbian OS phones than all other OS-based cell phones combined! Symbian has another very significant advantage—it's very stable, more so than Windows Mobile, and infinitely more so than firmware phones, which are prone to errors and freezes.

We must also keep in mind that Symbian was designed not for high-end PDAs but for handheld devices with limited resources, (like smartphones), this makes Symbian the near perfect platform for multimedia phones and smartphones.

cheaper one, is supposed to do better in most, if not all of the tests thrown at it.

Looks-wise the Philips 768 really took us by storm, it's small, sleek and curvy, with mock chrome and a steel grey-silver finish that was as appealing as water in a desert! It's got the functionality as well, with a more than decent camera and integrated flash. The keypad layout is good, the joystick is fluid, and the keypad backlight is a cool blue that is functional without being intrusive. The 768 has a good display that's clear and crisp. If looks were all that mattered we'd have a winner here.

The Nokia 6630, despite its pluses, has an odd shape—the bottom of the phone widens out, giving the base a much larger rounded footprint—that some love to hate, and others hate to love! The Nokia 6260, the only clamshell model here, featured a swivel screen, but is still nothing special. The Sony Ericsson W550i, sported the most unconventional look and colour, with a bright orange and silver body, giving it a young and trendy feel. The Nokia 6670 looks like a more serious version of their funkier looking 7610.

Coming to camera quality the Sony Ericsson K750i completely ruled the roost, followed by the Nokia 6630 and 3230 and Samsung X700. The autofocus feature on the K750i works well, we were able focus on the object first and then shoot. What happens is pressing the camera button slightly will result in a small focus window, which automatically focuses just like a camera. The 2.0 megapixel camera also meant that in terms of raw pixel count, this camera was way ahead of the other in this price range.

The Nokia 6630 was a distant second, with its large lens and camera rated at 1.3 megapixels. A

neat feature was the zoom of the 6630, it's absolutely smooth. The smoothness of the zoom was even better than the K750i. The Nokia 3230 and Samsung X700 fought it out for the third place, the quality of images and video being about equal, though the edge would probably go to the Samsung, due to its crisper screen.

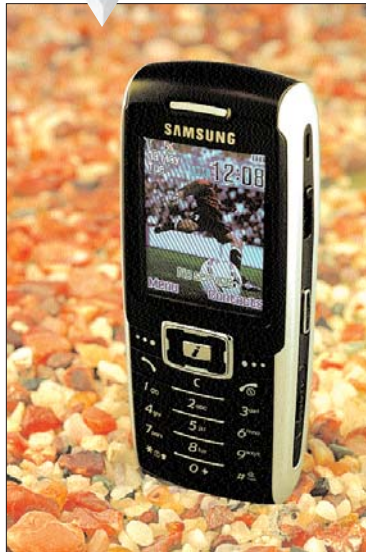
As far as overall image quality goes, while these cell phones certainly aren't in digicam territory yet, they are slowly getting within striking distance. Daylight shots are definitely good, with some very high quality images. Engaging Night Mode, or photo shooting in dim or dark lighting conditions is where all the cell

phones lose out, and badly. Video shooting under these conditions is even worse. There is no way that any of these cell phones can be used for after dark shooting. The K750i also gave the best quality video shooting, followed by the 6630.

The Nokia 6260 gave some of the lowest quality shots, testament to its ageing sub-megapixel camera. A surprise bad performer here was the W550i, its 1.3 megapixel camera just did not live up to its technical specs, and our expectations.

As far as screen clarity goes, the Nokia 6630 is just great, owing to a very classy looking set of default icons, with a sort of shadow effect around them, overall a very professional businesslike look! Seeing as it's a 65K colour screen, we couldn't spot any discernable difference between this and the 262K screens.

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The Samsung X700—The best screen in its class